

WELCOME TO SRI LANKA

A guest guide to the island

The visa, getting around, what to see, where to stay, who can organise it, and the numbers to save. Names in blue open Google Maps.

WEDDING Monday 21st December 2026, 4 PM onwards

VENUE [Anantara Kalutara Resort](#), Kalutara, about 42 km south of Colombo

AIRPORT Bandaranaike International, Katunayake (CMB), 1.5 to 2 hours from the venue

ON THE DAY 4 PM tea and refreshments · 5 PM arrival of the bride and groom · 5:25 PM poruwa ceremony · 6:15 PM signing of the register · then the hall: oil lamp, cake, speeches, dinner and the group photograph, dancing · going away after 11 PM

VISA Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA): German and Indian passport holders need an ETA before flying: a free online pre-approval linked to your passport. Without it airlines can refuse boarding. Apply only at the official site, eta.gov.lk (look-alike sites charge fake fees): choose Apply as Individual, then Tourist ETA. Approval comes by email in one to three days; apply two to three weeks ahead and save or print it. Your passport must be valid for six months or more. Other nationalities: check the same site.

AT THE WEDDING DINNER

One plate, many trips to the buffet

A small Sri Lankan custom, easy to miss, that helps us more than you might think.

At a Sri Lankan hotel wedding, the kitchen does not count guests by the list we give them. It counts the **main dinner plates** that come back at the end of the night, and that number is what we are charged for. So every extra plate looks, to the hotel, like an extra guest.

Keep your one main plate for the whole dinner. Go back to the buffet as often as you like with it: the rice and curry are meant to be enjoyed in rounds.

Would you like a clean plate? Just ask any waiter and they will bring you a fresh one. Please do not take a new plate from the stack at the buffet.

The small plate beside your main plate is for bones, shells and anything you would rather set aside, so your main plate stays yours.

Dessert glasses, side plates and drinks are not counted. Help yourself to as many as you wish.

Thank you for indulging us in this. It is the quiet way the hotel keeps its count, and it lets us feed everyone generously without a surprise at the end.

GOOD TO KNOW

Getting around and local tips

Transport

PickMe, the local ride app, like Uber. Cheap and reliable; get it before you arrive. Good for long rides too: a car with a driver for a day, a few days, or a trip across the island, booked in the app with the fare shown before you confirm.

Uber works in Colombo and on the west coast.

Tuk-tuks are everywhere. Book one through PickMe for a fixed fare, or agree the price first.

Car and driver for the whole stay is the easiest way to tour: see [People we know](#).

Trains are scenic but slow.

Driving yourself? [Message us](#), we can help.

Money

The currency is the Rupee (LKR). **Carry cash**: many tuk-tuks, shops and temples are cash only. ATMs are in towns; cards work at hotels. Tip a little at restaurants when there is no service charge, round up tuk-tuks, and tip drivers and guides.

Staying connected

Buy a tourist SIM or eSIM at the airport (Dialog or Mobitel). Everyone uses WhatsApp. Plugs are the three-pin Type G and Type D, 230 V, so bring an adapter.

Hair and dressing on the day

For the ladies: **Boho Lounge** in [Piliyandala](#), a hairdresser and beauty salon trained in Paris and now in Sri Lanka, does hair, make-up and saree dressing for the wedding. Book on [+94 77 003 1157](#), or with the owner, Oshadi, on [+33 6 59 76 82 75](#), and say Hansi gave you the number. Would you like to buy a saree and jacket on the same day? [Message Maheshika](#) and we will arrange it.

Mosquitoes

Pack a repellent. It is the one thing that matters: dengue goes around on the coast.

From home: Anti Brumm, Autan, or any spray with DEET or icaridin.

In Sri Lanka: Odomos cream or Soffell spray from any supermarket or pharmacy, plus coils or a plug-in for the room.

When: busiest early morning, 5 to 7 PM, and after rain. The dengue mosquito bites in daylight, so use it by day too.

Evenings: long sleeves help. Hotels near the venue have air conditioning and screens.

Vaccinations and health

Nothing is required to enter from Europe or India. No malaria tablets: Sri Lanka has been malaria-free since 2016.

Usually suggested: routine vaccines up to date, plus hepatitis A; typhoid for longer or rural stays.

Dengue vaccine (Qdenga): it exists, but needs two doses three months apart, so it is too late for a full course before December. In Germany it is officially advised only after a previous dengue infection; in India it is not on sale until 2027. Ask your doctor; for most of us, repellent is the protection.

See your doctor or a travel clinic four to six weeks before you fly.

On the island: drink bottled water, and do not pet stray dogs.

Temples and etiquette

Cover shoulders and knees, remove shoes and hats, carry a scarf. Never turn your back to a Buddha statue for a photo.

Be a little careful

Some drivers steer you to gem or spice shops on commission; decline. Agree every price upfront. Swim only where there are flags or lifeguards; currents can be strong. Monkeys grab food, phones and sunglasses at temples and Sigiriya. Drink bottled water, use repellent, wear SPF 50 or higher, and watch belongings in crowds.

Booking a hotel

Our advice: book on the **hotel's own website** whenever you can, and read the **Google reviews** first; Booking.com is fine when the hotel has no site of its own. Choose a hotel over an Airbnb: a hotel has staff around the clock and someone to call if anything goes wrong. Check the current rating and price when you book.

Food and shopping

Try rice and curry, hoppers and string hoppers, kottu roti, fresh seafood, curd and treacle, king coconut and the short eats. Bring home Ceylon tea (we drink [Dilmah](#)), cinnamon from [Cinnamon Lavish](#) and other spices, batik and linen, Ayurveda products from [Siddhalepa](#) or [Spa Ceylon](#), and sapphires only from trusted shops.

THINGS TO DO

Close to the venue, and across the island

The first cards are an easy afternoon from Kalutara; the rest is by city, for anyone staying on.

Around the wedding

Kalutara beach and the sunset, a [Kalu Ganga boat ride](#), the [Kalutara Bodhiya](#) temple, [Richmond Castle](#), and [Brief Garden](#) by Bevis Bawa.

Bentota and Kosgoda

25 minutes south. [Bentota beach](#) for swimming and water sports, and the [Kosgoda turtle hatchery](#).

Galle Fort

About an hour. A Dutch colonial fort by the sea: the ramparts, the [lighthouse](#) and [clock tower](#), boutiques and cafés inside [the fort](#). Land inside the walls is now among the most expensive in Sri Lanka, over 20 million rupees a perch, since so many of the old houses were bought by foreigners.

Ayurveda and wellness

[Siddhalepa Ayurveda](#), the island's best-known Ayurveda name: the [hospital and spa in Mount Lavinia](#) just south of Colombo, and the doctor-led [health resort in Wadduwa](#) near the venue. [Spa Ceylon](#) in Colombo and Galle Fort (day spa and shops). In Kandy, [Hill City Retreat](#) on Bowalawatta Road: authentic Ayurveda treatments from a facial or head massage (USD 30 to 35) to the full body massage, shirodhara and herbal bath (USD 100), [+94 77 081 1562](#). The [Anantara Spa](#) at the venue is lovely and expensive.

Colombo

Port City, the new district on reclaimed land, is where the fun is: karting at **SpeedBay**, a golf driving range on the sea, ATV rides on the dunes, a sunset cruise from the marina, the casino, duty-free shopping for visitors (collected at the airport when you leave), and the best sunset and view of the city. Nearby, the **Dutch Hospital** by the World Trade Centre has the cafés, bars and night life.

Gangaramaya Temple and **Seema Malaka** on the lake, **Galle Face Green** at sunset, **Independence Square**, **Viharamahadevi Park**, the **Colombo National Museum** for the history, the **Lotus Tower** (about USD 20 a person for the observation deck and the digital art museum).

Shopping and food: **One Galle Face**, **Cinnamon Life**, **Colombo City Centre** and **Havelock City Mall**; tea and a light meal at **Dilmah Urban Estate** at One Galle Face; and try at least one five-star buffet, at **ITC Ratnadipa**, **Cinnamon Life** or the **Hilton**.

Kandy

The **Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic**, the island's holiest Buddhist shrine (light-coloured clothing, shoulders and knees covered), **Kandy Lake**, the **Kandy View Point**, a Kandyan dance show, and the **Royal Botanical Gardens** at Peradeniya. The **Ambuluwawa Tower** is a detour of about an hour each way and a narrow spiral climb, better for a small group.

For the history, **Ehelepola Walawwa**, a noble house of the last Kandyan kings that the British turned into a prison: since 2025 the island's first wax museum, the old cells turned into a shopping arcade, and at the King's Court a dinner served the way the royal court ate, about LKR 12,000 a person, reserve ahead. For a treatment, **Hill City Retreat** (see Ayurveda and wellness). To stay: **Kandy Myst by Cinnamon**, new in 2025 with a rooftop pool over the hills.

Nuwara Eliya

Tea country and colonial charm. **Gregory Lake**, a factory tour and tasting at **Pedro Tea Estate** (about LKR 500 to 1,000 a person), **Horton Plains** with World's End at dawn, and the waterfalls at **Lover's Leap** and **Bambarakanda**. **Adam's Peak**, a dawn pilgrimage climb, is in season from December. Pack a warm layer: 10 to 15 degrees at night.

Ella

Take the morning train from **Nanu Oya** to Ella, one of the great rides, in that direction. Then the **Nine Arch Bridge**, **Little Adam's Peak** (a gentle hike), Ella Rock for the keen, **Ravana Falls**, **Diyaluma Falls**, and **Lipton's Seat** if time permits. For an afternoon off, the **Ravana Pool Club**, a pool bar above the valley.

South coast

Whale and dolphin watching from **Mirissa** (November to April) and its beach bars and **Coconut Tree Hill**, snorkelling, diving and turtles at **Hikkaduwa**, diving and kayaking at **Unawatuna**, surfing at **Weligama** (good for beginners), **Jungle Beach** and the **Japanese Peace Pagoda** at Unawatuna, and the beaches at **Unawatuna** and **Ahangama**.

Yala and the safari parks

A dawn safari in **Yala** (5:30 AM pick-up; leopards and elephants, and a jeep we can recommend), then the **Kataragama Temple**. **Udawalawe** for elephants (easy, reliable, good with families), **Minneriya** for the elephant gathering, paired with Sigiriya. **Wilpattu** is quiet with fewer jeeps; **Kumana** is remote, for longer trips.

Waterfalls

[Bambarakanda](#), the island's tallest, and [Diyaluma](#) near Ella with its natural pools at the top; [Ravana Falls](#) right by the Ella road; [St. Clair's](#) and [Devon Falls](#) seen from the road near Talawakelle on the way to Nuwara Eliya; [Lover's Leap](#) above Nuwara Eliya; [Dunhinda](#) near Badulla; and [Bopath Ella](#), shaped like a bo leaf, near Ratnapura. These are the famous ones; the island has hundreds more.

Tea, from bush to cup

A factory tour and tasting at [Pedro Tea Estate](#) or the [Damro Tea Centre](#) (the former Labookellie) near Nuwara Eliya, and the [Ceylon Tea Museum](#) in Kandy. In Colombo, [Dilmah Urban Estate](#) at One Galle Face, opened in 2026, is the place to taste and buy: single-estate brews, iced teas and tea cocktails, and the whole [Dilmah](#) range to take home.

Cultural triangle

[Sigiriya](#), the Lion Rock with its frescoes and huge views (climb at dawn; for the sunrise or sunset over Sigiriya itself, climb [Pidurangala](#), the rock opposite), the [Dambulla cave temple](#) with its murals and rows of Buddha statues, and the ancient royal cities of [Polonnaruwa](#) and [Anuradhapura](#), best by bicycle. We do not recommend the Pinnawala elephant orphanage; the animals are not well treated there.

WHERE TO STAY

From the grandest to the most sensible

For the wedding, stay near the venue: Kalutara, Wadduwa, Waskaduwa, Bentota or Beruwala. The first four names are the closest. Where a hotel has an official Sri Lanka Tourism star grade, that is the group it is in; the boutique and luxury resorts are mostly ungraded and sit by price and reputation. Booking tips are under Good to know.

Five star and luxury

[Anantara Kalutara Resort](#) (the venue), [Blue Water](#) (Wadduwa), [Cinnamon Bentota Beach](#), [Taj Bentota Resort & Spa](#), [Shangri-La Colombo](#), [Cinnamon Life at City of Dreams](#), [The Kingsbury](#), [Taj Samudra](#), [Galle Face Hotel](#) (heritage), [Amari Colombo](#), [Amangalla](#) (Galle Fort), [Le Grand Galle](#), [Cape Weligama](#), [Marriott Weligama Bay](#), [Jetwing Lighthouse](#) (near Galle), [Anantara Peace Haven](#) (Tangalle), [Amanwella](#) (Tangalle), [Ceylon Tea Trails](#) (Hatton), [Heritage Kandalama](#) (Dambulla), [Jetwing Vil Uyana](#) (Sigiriya), [Earl's Regency](#) (Kandy), [Jetwing Kaduruketha](#) (Wellawaya, among paddy fields), [Wild Coast Tented Lodge](#) (Yala), [Uga Chena Huts](#) (Yala), [Hilton Yala](#) (Yala), [Jetwing Yala](#) (Yala), [The Grand Hotel](#) (Nuwara Eliya, heritage), [98 Acres Resort & Spa](#) (Ella, a luxury boutique resort on a tea estate), [Kotiyagala by The One](#) (Yala), [Residence by Uga](#) (Colombo), [Uga Jungle Beach](#) (Trincomalee), [Cinnamon Lodge Habarana](#), [Sentido Heritage Negombo](#) (near the airport), [Cinnamon Grand](#) (Colombo), [Cinnamon Lakeside](#) (Colombo)

Four star and upscale

[Avani Kalutara Resort](#) (next to the venue), [Turyaa Kalutara](#), [Citrus Waskaduwa](#), [Earl's Reef](#) (Beruwala), [Jetwing Sea](#) (near the airport), [Riff Hikkaduwa](#), [Habarana Village by Cinnamon](#), [Aliya Resort & Spa](#) (Sigiriya), [Araliya Red](#) (Nuwara Eliya), [Araliya Green Hills](#) (Nuwara Eliya), [Laya Safari](#) (Yala), [Trinco Blu by Cinnamon](#) (Trincomalee), [Kandy Myst by Cinnamon](#) (Kandy, new in 2025), [Cinnamon Wild Yala](#) (Yala), [Heritance Tea Factory](#) (Kandapola), [Royal Palms Beach Hotel](#) (Kalutara North, about 10 minutes from the venue; ungraded, sold as five star)

Three star, boutique and village stays

[Clove Beach](#) (Wadduwa, adults only), [Reef Villa & Spa](#) (Wadduwa), [Mermaid Hotel & Club](#), [Seagate Hotel](#), [The Villa Bentota](#), [Paradise Road Tintagel](#) (Colombo), [Fort Bazaar](#) (Galle Fort), [Kahanda Kanda](#) (near Galle), [Amaroo](#) (Hikkaduwa), [Haritha](#) (Hikkaduwa), [W15](#) (Ahangama), [Crystal Apartments](#) (Mirissa), [Camellia Hills](#) (Hatton), [Mandira Bungalows](#) (Hatton), [Hilldale Retreat](#) (Nuwara Eliya), [EKHO Ella](#) (Ella), [Hide Ella](#) (Ella), [Queens Hotel](#) (Kandy, historic), [Mapakada Village](#) (Mahiyanganaya, a lakeside village retreat), [Adaar Kuchchaveli](#) (Trincomalee), [Leopard Corridor](#) (Yala), [Cinnamon Citadel](#) (Kandy, three star), [Cinnamon Red](#) (Colombo, three star, lively and central), [Tangerine Beach Hotel](#) (Kalutara, three star), [Thaala Bentota](#) (three star), [The Palms](#) (Beruwala, three star), [Golden Ridge](#) (Nuwara Eliya), [Amagi Aria](#) (Negombo)

A safe pick anywhere: the Cinnamon hotels (Cinnamon Grand, Lakeside, Life and Red in Colombo, Bentota Beach, Citadel and Kandy Myst in Kandy, Lodge and Habarana Village, Wild Yala, Trinco Blu) are reliably good and reasonably priced wherever you go.

Trincomalee and the east coast are best from May to September; in December choose the west or south coast.

PEOPLE WE KNOW

If you would rather have it organised

People we know and trust. Say it is for Maheshika and Moksha's wedding.

Trips and tours

[Ceylon Backroads](#) plan whole itineraries, from a day trip to a week: Gayathri on [+94 76 701 1364](#).

Yala safari

For the jeep we recommend for the dawn safari in Yala, message Sonu, Maheshika's brother: [+94 77 275 2920](#).

Car, van or bus with driver

Nadun Gallege hires out cars, vans and buses with a driver, for a day or for the whole trip: [+94 77 469 9687](#).

NUMBERS TO SAVE

Before you travel

The short numbers work from any local SIM.

Police	119 (or 118)
Ambulance, free (Suwa Seriya)	1990
Fire and rescue	110
Tourist police	1912
Government information	1919
National Hospital Colombo, accident service	+94 11 269 1111
Maheshika (Hansi), the bride	+49 172 2860593
Geethgaya, Maheshika's mother	+94 77 663 7034
Sonu, Maheshika's brother, local help	+94 77 275 2920

We cannot wait to celebrate with you in Sri Lanka.

Maheshika & Moksha